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Is It True? Fact-Checking AI

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AGES 9–12 · ONE LESSON + A GAME YOU'LL REPLAY ALL YEAR

Is it true? Teaching kids to fact-check AI

The most important AI skill for a 9-to-12-year-old isn't prompting — it's doubting well. AI states wrong things in a confident voice, and kids (like adults) believe confident voices. This lesson gives your learner a three-step check and a game that turns healthy skepticism into a family sport.

THE IDEA, IN KID WORDS

AI is a guessing machine with a confident voice.
A guess is not the same as knowing — so we check.

Teach the three-step check (10 minutes)

- 1 **Does it name a source I could look at?** "Scientists say" isn't a source. A book, a specific website, a person with a name — those can be checked.
- 2 **Can I find it in two other places?** The two-places rule: something true about the world usually shows up in more than one spot — an encyclopedia, a library book, a trusted site.
- 3 **Does it survive the "wait, what?" test?** If a claim is surprising, exciting, or exactly what you hoped was true, it earns extra checking, not less.

The game: Two Truths and an AI

Setup (grown-up, 2 minutes): Using your own AI account, ask: *"Give me two true, surprising, kid-friendly facts about [TOPIC YOUR KID LOVES] and one false fact that sounds just as believable. Don't label which is which."* Print or read them aloud.

Play: Your learner runs the three-step check with real books or a search you supervise, and votes: which one is the fake? Then reveal.

*"Notice how the fake one **sounded exactly as confident** as the real ones? That's the whole lesson. The voice never tells you what's true — checking does."*

When they catch a real AI mistake

It will happen — a wrong date, a made-up book title, a mangled fact about their favorite animal. Celebrate it like a goal scored: *"You out-checked the machine."* Kids who've personally caught AI being wrong are permanently harder to fool — by chatbots, by videos, by anything with a confident voice.

House rules that make this stick:

- The grown-up holds the keyboard — chatbot accounts are for 13+; the checking skills are for everyone.
- "Let's check" is said with excitement, never as a gotcha.
- One caught mistake per week gets bragging rights at dinner.

More for this age: our free Family AI Rules poster puts "AI guesses, we check" on the wall — and Launch It, our young-entrepreneur kit for ages 9–12, uses these same checking skills on real business decisions. Both in our TpT store.

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